

Email and SES Field Guide

Amazon SES suppression, bounce rate, DKIM and DMARC alignment.

8 fixes, each one a written note with diagrams and a small Python and Node.js script that finds the problem and repairs it. All 8 have a script in the public repo.

Before you run anything. Every script starts in a dry run: it reports what it would change and writes nothing. Read that output first, then set `DRY_RUN=false` when you are satisfied it has understood your data.

Scripts: github.com/allanninal/email-ses-fixes

Guides: allanninal.dev/email

All 14 repos: github.com/allanninal

The fixes

1 missing List-Unsubscribe now gets bulk mail rejected outright

This one changed underneath everyone. When Google and Yahoo introduced their bulk-sender rules in February 2024, non-compliant mail was deferred with a 4xx — annoying, retryable, survivable. Since November 2025 it is a permanent 550 rejection. Mail that was merely slow last year does not arrive at all now, and the fix is two headers most templates never had.

[check_list_unsubscribe.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/email/list-unsubscribe-missing/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/email-ses-fixes/tree/main/list-unsubscribe-missing>

2 provider records added to the root instead of the sending subdomain

The provider gave you three CNAMEs. You pasted them into your DNS host, waited, and verification is still pending an hour later. dig says the records exist and resolve correctly. They do — they are just not where the provider is looking. The records were meant for `send.yourdomain.com` and they went on `yourdomain.com`, one label short.

[provider_dns_check.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/email/provider-records-added-to-the-root-domain/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/email-ses-fixes/tree/main/provider-records-added-to-the-root-domain>

3 **SES bounce rate creeping toward account review**

Nobody watches the SES reputation dashboard daily. The number that matters is a rolling average, so a bad import on Tuesday keeps pushing the average up all week while each individual day looks survivable. By the time an email from AWS arrives saying the account is under review, the damage is a fortnight old and the fix — cleaning the list — takes longer than the review does.

[ses_reputation_watch.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/email/ses-bounce-rate-approaching-review/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/email-ses-fixes/tree/main/ses-bounce-rate-approaching-review>

4 **SES identity still shows verified but its DKIM records have drifted**

Someone moved the DNS to a new provider and exported the old zone to do it. The export missed the three Easy DKIM CNAMEs, because they are long, look like machine noise, and nobody remembered what they were for. SES kept reporting the identity as verified for a while, mail kept sending, and the only visible change was that DMARC reports slowly filled with failures nobody was reading.

[ses_dkim_drift_check.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/email/ses-identity-verified-but-dkim-drifted/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/email-ses-fixes/tree/main/ses-identity-verified-but-dkim-drifted>

5 **SES passes SPF and DKIM but DMARC still fails**

The authentication headers look like a pass. spf=pass. dkim=pass. And then dmarc=fail, which reads like a contradiction until you look at what SPF actually authenticated. Without a custom MAIL FROM domain, SES uses its own amazonses.com subdomain as the Return-Path, so SPF passes for that domain — not for the one in your From header. DMARC requires alignment, and those two do not align.

[ses_mail_from_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/email/ses-mail-from-not-set/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/email-ses-fixes/tree/main/ses-mail-from-not-set>

6 **SES bounces and complaints are invisible with no event destination**

This is the note that makes the other five findable. SES returns a MessageId the moment it accepts a request, and that is the last thing most applications ever learn about the message. Whether it was delivered, bounced, suppressed, or complained about is published as an event — and if no configuration set carries an event destination, those events go nowhere and the information is simply lost.

[ses_event_destination_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/email/ses-no-event-destination/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/email-ses-fixes/tree/main/ses-no-event-destination>

7 **SES silently rejects real recipients because the account is still in the sandbox**

Every test you ran worked. You sent to yourself, to a colleague, to a second address you own, and all of them arrived. Then the first real customer signed up and the send threw MessageRejected: Email address is not verified. Nothing changed in your code. The account is still in the SES sandbox, and the sandbox only lets you mail addresses you have already proved you control — which is exactly every address you tested with.

[ses_sandbox_check.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/email/ses-still-in-sandbox/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/email-ses-fixes/tree/main/ses-still-in-sandbox>

8 **SES suppression list silently blocks a real customer**

The customer swears the password reset never arrived. Your logs show the send succeeded. SES returned a message ID and no error. Nothing is in the spam folder, and the address is spelled correctly. What actually happened is that SES accepted the call, matched the address against your account-level suppression list, and dropped the message before it ever left AWS — because six months ago that address hard bounced once, while the mailbox was full.

[ses_suppression_audit.py](#)

<https://www.allanninal.dev/email/ses-suppression-list-blocks-a-real-customer/>

<https://github.com/allanninal/email-ses-fixes/tree/main/ses-suppression-list-blocks-a-real-customer>
